Engaged Learning: A Short Guide

EC325: Econometrics | Colby College

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Engaged learning is 5% of your grade in this course. That is small enough that you shouldn't manage it strategically, and large enough that it's worth knowing what it means. This guide is about the second part.

The syllabus says you can demonstrate engaged learning by asking and answering questions in class, coming to office hours, coordinating group members, and helping your classmates with the course material. Here is what each of those actually looks like.

One thing up front: engagement is supposed to feel like work. Students in classrooms that demand active participation reliably learn more than students who sit and listen, and just as reliably *feel* like they learned less—because following a clear lecture feels smoother than thinking hard does (Deslauriers et al. 2019). If class feels harder than reading the notes at home, that is the method working, not you failing.

In class

Econometrics moves fast, and the gap between "I followed that" and "I could do that" is wide. Talking is how you find the gap while there's still time to close it.

- **Arrive with a question already written down.** The concept check you submitted Sunday, or the reading, will have produced at least one. Ask it in the first ten minutes.
- **Answer when you're not sure.** A wrong answer said out loud is worth more to the room than a right answer said silently. It is also the cheapest way to find out you misunderstood something before an exam does it for you.
- **Ask the clarifying question.** If you are lost, several other people are lost in the same place and none of them have said so yet.
- **Respond to a classmate, not only to me.** "Building on that—does it also mean. . . ?" is a real contribution.
- **Interpret, don't just compute.** When output goes up on the board, say what the coefficient *means*. That is the actual skill this course is teaching.

If speaking in front of the room is hard for you, that is common, and it is not a barrier to a strong engaged learning grade. Email me a question, bring it to office hours, take a real role in the small-group work we do in class. What I am looking for is evidence that you are wrestling with the material somewhere I can see it.

On attendance: unexcused absences count against this grade. Tell me ahead of time about extracurricular conflicts, and don't come to class sick—just email me so we can keep you from falling behind.

In your group

The final project runs the length of the semester and has five checkpoints before the final report. Groups that do well treat those as deadlines for the group, not for whoever happened to draw that task.

- **Divide the work, not the project.** Every member should be able to explain the identification strategy, not just the person who wrote that section. You will each present, and the exam will not care who did which part.
- **Write your agreements down at your first meeting.** How you communicate, how fast you reply, when you meet, who does what by when. Ten minutes at the start prevents most of what goes wrong in week 11. There is a fill-in template in the resources below.
- **Raise problems early.** A group member who has gone quiet in week 6 is a solvable problem. In week 13 it is not.
- **Take the peer review seriously.** It asks about each member's contribution, including your own, and it feeds into this grade. It measures contribution, not how much you enjoyed working with someone.

When you're stuck

Getting help early is engagement. Struggling silently for a week is not, and it costs you far more than the question would have.

- **Office hours are not only for emergencies.** Come in week 2 with a question about the reading. Come with your project data. Come because you're not sure whether you should be worried. Bring something specific—"I'm confused about IV" is much harder to help with than "I don't see why the exclusion restriction holds in this paper."
- **Ask coding questions well.** Say what you were trying to do, what you ran, what you expected, and what actually happened, including the exact error message. In R the best version of this is a *reprex*: the smallest self-contained snippet that reproduces the problem. Building one solves the problem outright most of the time, and when it doesn't, it is the difference between a two-minute answer and a twenty-minute one.
- **Helping a classmate counts, and it isn't charity.** Explaining something is the fastest way to discover which parts you only thought you understood.
- **On concept checks.** These are individual—no classmates, no AI—but you can email me or come to office hours, and you should. If you find yourself wanting to hand a concept check to an AI, treat that as information: it is telling you where the gap is, and the useful response is to bring it to me.

A thirty-second weekly check

Do this Sunday, right after you submit the concept check.

- Did I ask or answer at least one question out loud this week?
- Did I write down a question I couldn't resolve—and take it somewhere?
- Did I do something for my group that wasn't strictly my assigned task?
- Did I explain something to a classmate, or have something explained to me?
- Is there anything I am quietly hoping will make sense later on its own?

That last one is the important one. It won't.

Resources

Participating in class

- Princeton, McGraw Center. Participating in Class Discussion: Contributions That Count — a concrete list of contributions that are not "talk the most."
- Penn, Weingarten Center. Classroom Participation: Making Contributions That Count — written for students who find speaking up genuinely hard.
- Deslauriers et al. (2019), *PNAS* 116(39). Measuring actual learning versus feeling of learning — the study behind "it feels worse and works better."

Working in your group

- Rutgers Learning Centers. A Guide to Working in Groups — includes what to do about the member who dominates, the member who disappears, and uneven effort.
- York University Learning Commons. Student Guide to Group Work and Group Charter Template — fill-in template with a worked example. Use this at your first group meeting.
- Waterloo, Centre for Teaching Excellence. Making Group Contracts — prompts and a sample contract if you would rather build your own.

Getting help

- UNC Learning Center. Using Office Hours Effectively — a before / during / after checklist.
- Harvard College. A Guide to Office Hours — the same advice from a student's point of view.
- Wickham, Çetinkaya-Rundel, and Grolemund. *R for Data Science* (2e), Ch. 8: Workflow—Getting Help — how to search an error message and build a reprex.
- tidyverse.org. Get help! — the `reprex` package, and where R questions get answered.